

other software, ExpressVPN opens up multiple windows for each option in the main menu. The split tunneling feature allows for users to easily specify the service on a per app basis, allowing users to create a whitelist of apps that use the VPN, or a blacklist of apps that do not use the VPN.

NordVPN

SCORE:
6.57

RANK:
5

NordVPN was founded in 2012, and is based in Panama, which is not a part of any of the Eyes alliances.

Like ExpressVPN, NordVPN is also one of the founders of the VTI, and is involved in the advocacy of privacy technologies for end users, irrespective of the providers that they use. NordVPN does have a warrant canary, which it introduced in 2017, and what is more this warrant canary is updated daily! The no logs policy of NordVPN has been externally audited multiple times by PricewaterhouseCoopers and VerSprite. In all these audits, the no logging policies of NordVPN was reviewed, and attested for, indicating the security of user data. Like ExpressVPN, Nord offers diskless RAM servers, where all the data on the servers is lost once the server is powered down. This ensures that user information cannot be retrieved even if someone gets hold of the physical hardware. NordVPN also uses bastion servers as hosts. What this means is that the proxy servers are configured for just one function, with all the other functionalities removed, to reduce the attack surface for malicious actors, and

make the servers more secure. Users can additionally opt for a static IP address, so NordVPN scores high on security and privacy.

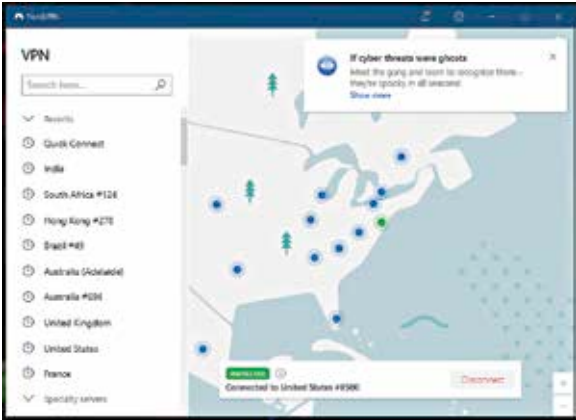
NordVPN uses a custom modified version of the snazzy new Wireguard protocol, known as NordLynx. Initially, the protocol was only available for Windows users, but in 2020, NordLynx introduced it across all their apps. Wireguard is faster than other protocols such as OpenVPN, is developed with inputs from academia, but is not as great at security as the alternatives. This is the aspect that NordVPN

worked on, making sure that the NordLynx protocol is both fast, as well as secure. Where this makes the biggest difference is rapid connectivity to the servers, so in service interruptions, the VPN connection is restored as soon as the service comes back online. Bear in mind that this brand new protocol is susceptible to bugs, as the underlying Wireguard protocol itself is under active development. If a slight compromise on speed for security is an acceptable trade off, then better off opting for the tried and tested protocols at this point of time.

With 5154 servers in 60 countries, NordVPN has a sizable network. There are no bandwidth caps, but only six simultaneous connections per account can be limiting for some users. There are apps available for all the major platforms. You can pay

for the NordVPN service through credit card, PayPal or GPay, and it also supports more cryptocurrencies than most, allowing payments in Ethereum, Ripple and Bitcoin. NordVPN has partnered with CoinPayments.net for this service, and thus supports other cryptocurrencies that are not tabulated or scored, including Bitcoin Cash, Litecoin, Dash, Tron, Monero and ZCash.

When it comes to performance, NordVPN got low speeds on streaming, and high speeds on torrenting. In fact, NordVPN was the top



performer when it came to torrent speeds, with ExpressVPN coming in a close second. The speeds were on the higher side across the board, no matter which country we connected to. When it comes to speed and performance, there does not seem to be any problem with NordVPN, as even though it scored low on the tests, streaming is not that much of a problem. Where NordVPN falls short is its memory use, and it is the most resource hungry of all the VPNs that we tested.

AVAILABILITY							
	Trial Period	Countries	Servers	Connections	Bandwidth	DNS Service	URL
CyberGhost	1 day	88	6000	7	1 Gbps	Yes	https://www.cyberghostvpn.com
ExpressVPN	No	94	3000	5	None	Yes	https://www.expressvpn.com
IPVanish	No	55	1300	Unlimited	None	Yes	https://www.ipvanish.com
NordVPN	No	60	5154	6	None	Yes	https://nordvpn.com
Private Internet Access	No	70	35,000	10	None	Yes	https://www.privateinternetaccess.com
PrivateVPN	No	63	200	6	None	Yes	https://privatevpn.com
PureVPN	No	140	2000	10	10 Gbps	No	https://www.purevpn.com
StrongVPN	No	35	950	12	None	No	https://strongvpn.com
Surfshark	No	65	3299	Unlimited	None	Yes	https://surfshark.com
VyprVPN	No	70	700	5	None	Yes	https://www.vyprvpn.com